

“To Transmit and Perpetuate the Fruits of This Victory:”
Union Regimental Histories, 1865-1866, and the Meaning of the Great Rebellion

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The regiment served as the basic building block of Civil War armies. Raised principally from a limited geographic area in a particular state, the regiment tied men at war to their home community. A regiment in the field represented the efforts of the home community to support the war. It should come as no surprise, then, that soldiers turned to documenting the history of their regiment for themselves and those at home. Beyond letters and newspaper articles published while still in the field, soldiers began to write regimental histories.

This essay seeks to investigate how Union soldiers viewed the meaning of the Civil War by examining the genre of regimental histories. It discusses the production of Northern regimental histories and the authors who wrote them before moving to a close analysis of the large numbers of histories that appeared in 1865 and 1866. Before the quite stunning content of these histories may be analyzed, the context of their production must be described at some length.

While historians make occasional use of regimental histories, the genre as a whole is usually dismissed in favor of other types of sources.¹ James M. McPherson, in a study

The quotation in the title is from Wood, *The Seventh Regiment*, 6.

¹ Historians have utilized individual regimental histories in a number of inventive ways, but have not attempted a complete survey of the genre. For instance, Peter Carmichael used the regimental history of the 15th New Jersey Infantry that was published in 1883, in conjunction with other primary source materials, to demonstrate how members of the regiment forged “a nostalgic view of soldiering that diminished the horrors of combat while expressing admiration for their former opponents.” Lesley Gordon, in a similar effort, used the regimental history of the 16th Connecticut Infantry as evidence of how “regimental and individual identities became subsumed by a national, corporate identity that had little room for variations or ambiguity.” Peter S. Carmichael, “We Respect a *Good* Soldier, Not Matter What Flag He

of how soldier motivation changed over the course of the war, wrote that regimental histories suffered “from a critical defect: they were written for publication.” Because McPherson sees letters and diaries as “more candid and far closer to the immediacy of experience than anything the soldiers wrote for publication then or later,” he does not need to deal with regimental histories in his book.² Other historians, such as Reid

Fought Under: The 15th New Jersey Remembers Spotsylvania,” in *The Spotsylvania Campaign*, ed. Gary W. Gallagher (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1998), 204; Lesley J. Gordon, “All Who Went into That Battle Were Heroes: Remembering the 16th Regiment Connecticut Volunteers at Antietam,” in *The Antietam Campaign*, ed. Gary W. Gallagher (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1999), 187. Modern regimental histories are quite numerous. Unfortunately, many of these modern histories are preoccupied simply with narrating battlefield experiences and refuse to engage with any sort of social history or secondary research. Despite this, there are several histories that make a brilliant use of the original regimental history to explore larger issues and themes. The best of these include: Mike Pride and Mark Travis, *My Brave Boys: To War With Colonel Cross and the Fighting Fifth* (Hanover, NH: University Press of New England, 2001) and Richard F. Miller, *Harvard’s Civil War: The History of the Twentieth Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry* (Hanover, NH: University Press of New England, 2005). Other authors have focused on writing new regimental histories, one of the more thought provoking is Mark H. Dunkelman, *Brothers One and All: Espirit de Corps in a Civil War Regiment* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 2006).

² James M. McPherson, *For Cause and Comrades: Why Men Fought in the Civil War* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1997), 11. Work that has appeared since *For Cause and Comrades* has shed light on the fact that diaries and letters were often intended for dissemination, and that their status as unpublished works does not necessarily mean that the opinions and thoughts expressed in them are somehow more authentic than published works. For a superb example of how letters and diaries were often constructed with a very specific audience in mind, see Robert L. Bee, ed., *The Boys from Rockville: The Civil War Narratives of*

Mitchell, have also focused on using sources other than regimental histories to make their arguments.³ Both McPherson and Mitchell examine individual soldiers, and the motivations and views of a particular soldier change over time. McPherson, in particular, then uses the information derived from investigating individual soldiers to make generalizations about Civil War soldiers as a group. The exclusion of regimental histories make perfect sense, as long as historians are charting the opinions of individual soldiers and how those individuals change over time.

The only historian to make widespread use of regimental histories was James I. Robertson, Jr., in *Soldiers Blue and Gray*.⁴ Robertson commented that his mentor, Bell

Sgt. Benjamin Hirst, Company D, 14th Connecticut Volunteers (Knoxville, TN: University of Tennessee Press, 1998).

³ Mitchell's work utilizes memoirs, reminiscences, and letters rather than regimental histories. See: Reid Mitchell, *Civil War Soldiers* (New York: Viking, 1988) and Reid Mitchell, *The Vacant Chair: The Northern Soldier Leaves Home* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993).

⁴ Historian Stephen Z. Starr attempted a survey of the genre of regimental histories with a brief article in 1964, but he was hampered by absence of a comprehensive bibliography of Civil War literature, so his conclusions remained provisional at best. The current standard military bibliography, Charles Dornbusch's *Military Bibliography of the Civil War*, had not been completed. Starr extrapolated from the limited available data to arrive at an astronomical estimate of more than 800 regimental histories. Starr was less than clear, as well, on what exactly he considered a regimental history. Based on these vague estimates, Starr proclaimed that "the golden age of the regimental history is the twenty-five-year span from 1885 to 1910." Subsequent historians have followed Starr's lead, using inflated extrapolations without reinvestigating how Starr arrived at those conclusions. Stephen Z. Starr, "The Grand Old Regiment," *Wisconsin Magazine of History* 48 (Autumn 1964), 22; Charles Dornbusch, *Military Bibliography of the Civil War* (3 vols., New York: New York Public Library, 1961-1972) and see Silas Felton, *Military*

I. Wiley had “bypassed a multitude of printed works such as the vast category of regimental histories” while writing the classic studies *The Life of Johnny Reb* and *The Life of Billy Yank*. Robertson’s aimed “to supplement those works” and covered the same ground that Wiley did – the experiences of soldiers in the field rather than any political or ideological motivations – except he used regimental histories instead of letters as his primary source of evidence. As Reid Mitchell wrote of *Soldiers Blue and Gray*, Robertson “studiously avoided tough questions – and new ones.”⁵ Rather than using regimental histories in a systematic manner, Robertson used them to provide anecdotes and vignettes about the experience of soldiering. Because Robertson was not concerned with examining what Civil War soldiers thought the purpose or meaning of the war was, he did not examine regimental histories for this sort of information. To historians concerned with ideology, motivation, and social history, it appeared as if regimental histories were bereft of value because Robertson had examined them and found nothing except further variations on what Wiley had argued forty years earlier.

Recent scholarship has further perpetuated the notion that regimental histories are not a source for information on important questions regarding the war, instead being valuable only to provide quaint, colorful details about battles and camp life. In a

Bibliography of the Civil War: Volume IV, Revised (Dayton: Morningside, 2003); A.F. Sperry, *History of the 33d Iowa Infantry Volunteer Regiment 1863-6*, ed. Gregory J.W. Urwin and Cathy Kunzinger Urwin (1866; Fayetteville: University of Arkansas Press, 1999), xix.

⁵ James I. Robertson, Jr., *Soldiers Blue and Gray* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1988), vii-viii.; Reid Mitchell, “Not the General but the Soldier: The Study of Civil War Soldiers,” in *Writing the Civil War: The Quest to Understand*, ed. James M. McPherson and William J. Cooper, Jr. (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1998), 86.

historiographical essay on the literature surrounding the role of the common soldier in the Civil War, Aaron Sheehan-Dean was dismissive of regimental histories. He wrote that “in the decades after the conflict, veterans, their relatives, and their admirers...compos[ed] thousands of regimental histories.” Despite this outpouring, Sheehan-Dean dubbed regimental histories “simultaneously antiquarian and heroic” and declared them not valuable because “the narrow focus and celebratory tone” rendered them useless for analytic studies of Civil War soldiers. To substantiate these broad assertions, Sheehan-Dean cited an example of a Union regimental history and a history of a Confederate cavalry company. Carol Reardon, a military historian who has written extensively about memory and Pickett’s Charge, overlooked the massive number of regimental histories that appeared in the years immediately following the end of the Civil War. According to Reardon, a history of Pickett’s division that appeared in 1870 “was among the first concise unit histories to appear in print on either side.”⁶ This statement

⁶ Sheehan-Dean provides as his examples Asa B. Isham, *An Historical Sketch of the Seventh Regiment Michigan Volunteer Cavalry* (New York: Town Topics, 1893) George T. Williams, *Company A, 37th Battalion Virginia Cavalry, C.S.A.: A History of Its Organization and Service in the War Between the States, 1861-1865* (Roanoke: R. H. Fishburne, 1910). Aaron Sheehan-Dean, “The Blue and the Gray in Black and White: Assessing the Scholarship on Civil War Soldiers,” in *The View from the Ground: Experiences of Civil War Soldiers*, ed. Aaron Sheehan-Dean (Lexington, KY: University of Kentucky Press, 2007), 10, 10 n1 and n2; Carol Reardon, “Pickett’s Charge: The Convergence of History and Myth in the Southern Past,” in *The Third Day at Gettysburg and Beyond*, ed. Gary W. Gallagher (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1994), 66.

overlooks the dozens of Union regimental histories that were published before 1870, as well as several other important unit histories on the Confederate side.⁷

Because historians have consistently overlooked, glossed, and ignored dealing with the genre of regimental histories as a whole, some context is needed. Like any other genre, regimental histories have their own set of assumptions, constraints, and conventions that inflect interpretation.

⁷ Also, this statement betrays the fact that systematic research on Civil War unit histories at all levels is lacking. In fact, dozens of Union regimental histories had been printed by 1870, as well as at least one brigade history, one division history, and one corps history. See: David Conygham, *The Irish Brigade and Its Campaigns: With Some Account of the Corcoran Legion, and Sketches of Principal Officers* (New York: W. McSorley & Co., 1867); J.R. Sypher, *History of the Pennsylvania Reserve Corps: A Complete Record of the Organization; and of the Different Companies, Regiments, and Brigades. Containing Descriptions of Expeditions, Marches Skirmishes, and Battles; Together With Biographical Sketches of Officers and Personal Records of Each Man During His Term of Service* (Lancaster: Elias Barr & Co., 1865); Augustus Woodbury, *Major General Ambrose E. Burnside and the Ninth Army Corps: A Narrative of Campaigns in North Carolina, Maryland, Virginia, Ohio, Kentucky, Mississippi, and Tennessee, During the War for the Preservation of the Republic* (Providence: S.S. Rider & Brother, 1867). Significant Confederate unit histories published before 1870 include: William H. Tunnard, *A Southern Record: The History of the Third Regiment Louisiana Infantry, Containing a Complete Record of the Campaigns in Arkansas and Missouri; the Battles of Oak Hills, Elk Horn, Iuka, Corinth; The Second Siege of Vicksburg, Anecdotes, Camps, Scenery, and Description of the Country through which the Regiment Marched* (Baton Rouge: n.p., 1866); *A Historical Sketch of the Quitman Guards: Company E, Sixteenth Mississippi Regiment, Harris' Brigade, From Its Organization in Holmesville, 21st April, 1861 to the Surrender of the Army of Northern Virginia, 9th April, 1865* (New Orleans: Isaac T. Hinton, 1866); and J.F.J. Caldwell, *History of a Brigade of South Carolinians, Known First as "Gregg's" and Subsequently "McGowan's" Brigade* (Philadelphia: King & Baird, 1866).

I. The Genre of Regimental Histories

The companies of a regiment usually came from the same geographic area, so they replicated the home community. When it came time to write the regimental histories, veterans committees often edited and compiled the book. Veterans wanted to capture the spirit of the regiment, and presented a history written not by a single voice but by a corporate voice. Typical was the history of the 73rd Illinois. In 1888, the Regimental Reunion Association “decided that a committee, consisting of three members of the Association, be appointed to prepare a history of the regiment.” This committee canvassed surviving members of the regiment for raw material. Once veterans provided this material, the committee began the process of writing the regimental. The committee congratulated itself, finding that “the work of this committee, as completed and show in full herein, seemed to strengthen the purpose as well as justify the labor of writing a full and complete history of the regiment from the time of its entry into service until its muster out.”⁸ The regimental history was the product of consensus. With a broad representation of the regiment involved in collecting information and writing the history,

⁸ Committee on Regimental History [W.H. Newlin, D.F. Lawler, and J.W. Sherrick], *A History of the Seventy-Third Regiment of Illinois Infantry Volunteers: Its Services and Experiences in Camp, on the March, on the Picket, and Skirmish Lines, and in Many Battles of the War, 1861-1865. Including a Sketch in Full of the Valuable and Indispensable Services Rendered by Opdycke's First Brigade, Second Division, Fourth Army Corps, in the Campaign in Tennessee in the Fall of 1864, Embracing an Account of the Movement from Columbia to Nashville, and the Battles of Spring Hill and Franklin. Also, Including Many Other Interesting Miscellaneous Sketches, the Latter Being Made Up of Recitals of Individual Experiences of Capture, Imprisonment, and Escape, and an Account of the Visit of James F. Jaquess, Colonel of the Seventy-Third, to Richmond, Virginia, in the Summer of 1864* ([Springfield]: n.p., 1890), 5.

one voice did not predominate. Recalling the experiences of the regiment took center stage, rather than any argument about politics or the greater meaning of the war. This is part of the reason why historians have dismissed regimental histories as a genre: they appear to be bland, chauvinistic efforts at commemorating a particular community.

County histories provide further evidence of the close links between home communities and their regiments. Many county histories written in the half-century following the Civil War included chapters describing the particular county's participation in the war. Beyond simply describing life at home during the Civil War, the county histories often included brief histories of regiments raised in the area.⁹ Even though the regiment served far away, the inclusion of its story in a history of the county underscores the close ties between the two.

Unit cohesion and ideas of community influenced the production of regimental histories, which explains why few regimental histories exist for units of heterogeneous composition. There are no regimental histories dealing solely with the Civil War service of particular units from the regular United States Army. These soldiers did not experience the same impulse to commemorate themselves or describe their service to their home communities. A similar dynamic, though one no doubt influenced by a general lack of education, affected the production of regimental histories for United States Colored Troops (USCT). Significantly, regimental histories produced for units that enlisted African-Americans often described the service of regiments associated with a particular state before being redesignated within the organization of the USCT. For instance, Louis Emilio's history of the famed 54th Massachusetts Infantry is widely

⁹ For example, see Henry L. Boies, *History of DeKalb County, Illinois* (Chicago: O.P. Bassett, 1868).

known, and went through two printings between 1891 and 1894. Less well known are the histories of the 55th Massachusetts Infantry and the 14th Rhode Island Heavy Artillery (Colored) which were also African-American units.¹⁰ Certainly, these units were raised primarily among educated Northern blacks, particularly the 54th Massachusetts. This provided greater source material for the historians, but it also demonstrated that the primary motivating nucleus behind the production of a regimental history was a coherent community of educated men concerned with recording their experiences and distributing them among themselves. It is hard to imagine that the publishers of these three histories of African-American regiments thought that there was a large market for their works. The prime difference between these three units and the other USCT regiments, or between them and the United States regulars, was that these three regiments were volunteer regiments from one place, whose members had voluntarily entered a military community.

Another aspect of regimental histories of vast importance is the fact that they were not commercial ventures. Some historians recognize this important feature; Gerald Linderman noted that “soldiers felt impelled to turn rapidly from the war.” For veterans, writing about the war was not simply about making a profit in the market; for the veteran

¹⁰ Louis F. Emilio, *History of the Fifty-fourth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry, 1863-1865* (Boston: Boston Book co., 1891), and Louis F. Emilio, *History of the Fifty-fourth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry, 1863-1865, Second Edition, Revised and Corrected, with Appendix upon Treatment of Colored Prisoners of War* (Boston: Boston Book co., 1894); Charles B. Fox, *Record of Service of the Fifty-fifth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry* (Cambridge: Press of John Wilson and Son, 1868); William H. Chenery, *The Fourteenth Regiment Rhode Island Heavy Artillery (Colored) in the War to Preserve the Union, 1861-1865* (Providence: Snow & Farnham, 1898).

there was more meaning behind the production of the regimental history.¹¹ The motivation behind the production of regimental histories was not profit, but commemoration. Several examples serve to drive this point home. Warren Billings, author of the history of the 10th Massachusetts (Sleeper's) Battery, wrote that a second edition of the history was published because new information from company record books had been added. This information, which provided evidence of presence or absence with the regiment, would be invaluable for veterans "in establishing claims for a pension." Commercial demand or popularity did not provoke a second printing, but rather the discovery and availability of materials that would assist the members of the regiment in receiving their pensions. The *History of the One Hundred and Fifty-Third Regiment Pennsylvania Volunteers Infantry* was not produced until the legislature of Pennsylvania made an appropriation for funds to purchase regimental histories of units from the state. The regimental association recommended "that our organization avail itself of the offer of the Commonwealth at the earliest practicable moment." The regimental history had to be underwritten in order to make it feasible. A final example is found with Benjamin Crowninshield, author of a history of the 1st Massachusetts Cavalry. When Crowninshield died, his estate still held a vast amount of unsold numbers of his

¹¹ Gerald Linderman, *Embattled Courage: The Experience of Combat in the American Civil War* (New York: Free Press, 1987), 268. For a thought-provoking investigation of popular histories of the war that appeared in 1865 and 1866, see Alice Fahs, *The Imagined Civil War: Popular Literature of the North and South, 1861-1865* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina, 2001), 287-310. Linderman acknowledges that there was a brief surge of interest in the war in 1865 and 1866, but other historians have overlooked this caveat. For an example of how some have overlooked Linderman's nuances, see Sperry, *History of the 33d Iowa Infantry Volunteer Regiment 1863-6*, xix.

regimental histories, and the regimental association made efforts to raise money to purchase these so that his estate would not take a loss.¹² Further evidence of the non-commercial intention of regimental histories is provided by the fact that very few were published by major printing houses. Most regimental histories were printed by local newspaper, steam, and job presses. Those that did appear from large New York, Chicago, or Boston publishing companies were printed, not published. This means that the large publication house did not subsidize or support the books, but printed them in return for payment. All of these aspects demonstrate that a desire for commercial success did not account for the production of regimental histories.

The Seventy-Seventh Pennsylvania at Shiloh shows the clearest convergence of all of these trends. This regimental history includes four portions: the “Report of the Pennsylvania Shiloh Battlefield Commission,” “Dedication of the Monument,” “History of the Seventy-Seventh Pennsylvania Volunteers,” and “Campaign and Battle of Shiloh.” As the only Pennsylvania unit present at Shiloh, the regimental association found it convenient to delegate the task of composing the regimental history to the same men who pushed for the erection of a monument on the battlefield. John Obreiter, chairman of the regimental association, oversaw the Pennsylvania Shiloh Battlefield Commission, as well

¹² Warren Billings, *The History of the Tenth Massachusetts Battery of Light Artillery in the War of the Rebellion, Formerly of the Third Corps, and Afterwards of Hancock’s Second Corps, Army of the Potomac, 1862-1865* (Boston: Arakelvan Press, 1909), 4; William R. Kiefer, *History of the One Hundred and Fifty-Third Regiment Pennsylvania Volunteers Infantry, Which was Recruited in Northampton County, Pa., 1862-1863* (Easton: Press of the Chemical Pub. Co., 1909), unpaginated front matter.; Benjamin Crowninshield, *A History of the First Regiment of Massachusetts Cavalry Volunteers*, ed., Frank O’Reilly (1891; Baltimore: Butternut and Blue, 1995), viii.

as the production of the regimental history. In this instance, the same committee linked the erection of the monument to the regimental history in a definite and enduring fashion. The sum total was intended to be “a permanent addition to the History of the old Keystone State in the great war between the States.”¹³

The true scope of the genre of regimental histories becomes apparent when the titles from Dornbusch’s *Military Bibliography of the Civil War* are placed in a graph that charts the number of regimental histories that were published in a particular year (see chart, page 53). The chart begins with the publication of the first true, complete regimental histories in 1863 and ends with the publication of the last primary source regimental history in 1921.¹⁴ The use of several criteria ensured an accurate tabulation of regimental histories.

¹³ John Obreiter, *The Seventy-Seventh Pennsylvania at Shiloh. History of the Regiment. The Battle of Shiloh* (Harrisburg: Harrisburg Pub. Co., 1905), 6.

¹⁴ The first complete regimental history to appear in 1863 was one of the following: Ovando J. Hollister, *History of the First Regiment of Colorado Volunteers* (Denver: Thos. Gibson & co., 1863), William P. Maxson, *Camp Fires of the Twenty-Third, Sketches of the Camp Life, Marches, and Battles of the Twenty-Third Regiment, N.Y.V., During the Term of Two Years in the Service of the United States. Added to These are Statistics of Enlistments, Elections, Promotions, Sick, Discharged, Killed, Wounded, and All Valuable Information Connected with the Regiment* (New York: Davies & Kent, 1863), or William Simmers and Paul Bachschmid, *The Volunteers Manual; or, Ten Months with the 153d Penn’a Volunteers, Being a Concise Narrative of the Most Important Events of the History of the Said Regiment* (Easton: P.H. Neiman, 1863). The last regimental history, however, is certainly Isaac O. Best, *History of the 121st New York State Infantry* (Chicago: [W.S. Conkey co.], 1921).

First, a regimental history had to contain twenty-five or more pages of text.

This eliminated unit rosters that did not include any discussion of the Civil War. Rosters themselves indicate very little about interest in the war, because they repackage and republish purely statistical information, often drawn from larger state publications on the Civil War. Beyond this, a pure roster contained very little discursive information and presented only compiled data. Shorter works often merely listed engagements and figures rather than discussing the war in any depth.¹⁵ Company histories, it should be noted, were also discounted for consideration for the chart. Although some historians conflate company and regimental histories, by definition the two are different. The concern here is with the dynamics and internal logic of the regimental history, so a thorough consideration of company histories fell outside the scope of this study.¹⁶

Second, a work had to be printed by itself to be considered a regimental history. This eliminated state-sponsored histories of their participation or reports published by state Adjutant Generals.¹⁷ This also disqualified articles that appeared in the papers of

¹⁵ For an example of this sort of work, see James E. Carpenter, compiler, *A List of the Battles, Engagements, Actions and Important Skirmishes in which the Eighth Pennsylvania Cavalry Participated During the War of 1861-1865* (Philadelphia: Allen, Lane & Scott's Print. House, 1886).

¹⁶ Though company histories are not discussed, and they do not appear on the chart, they were tabulated as they were encountered. Between 1863 and 1921, only thirty-four company histories were published. Obviously, these works appeared in a scale far less than that of regimental histories.

¹⁷ For a typical example of a state-level description of participation and the activities of regiments, see George Benedict, *Vermont in the Civil War: A History of the Part Taken by the Vermont Soldiers and Sailors in the War for the Union, 1861-1865*, 2 vols. (Burlington: Free Press Association, 1886-1888). An example of a state-level compilation of statistics and data from the adjutant general, see *Record of Service*

the Military Order of the Loyal Legion of the United States and other veterans' organizations. A state-level work failed to adequately examine the actions of individual regiments and utilized official company records rather than any sort of descriptive information from veterans. Simply put, state-level works exemplify bureaucratic summary rather than anything indicative of soldier experience. Articles in publications of veterans' organizations rarely considered the regiment as a whole, instead presenting brief synopses of battles, skirmishes, or personal experiences. Even if an article purported to tell the history of a regiment, it described only a very narrow section of a unit's service and did not embody the corporate effort integral to most regimental histories. In short, an article did not embody the characteristics of a regimental history.

Third, personal reminiscences and memoirs fell outside the definition of regimental history, even when these works made reference to including some history of a regiment. A regimental history was often produced by a corporate effort and aimed at telling the story of a particular military community, usually with reference to the civilian community from which the regiment came. Memoirs, autobiographies, and reminiscences exhibited different motives and meanings than those of regimental histories.¹⁸ For instance, a title such as George Perkins's *A Summer in Maryland and*

of Connecticut Men in the Army and Navy of the United States, During the War of the Rebellion. Compiled by the Authority of the General Assembly, Under Direction of the Adjutant General (Hartford: Press of Wiley, Waterman & Eaton, 1889).

¹⁸ For a discussion of the nature of memoirs, autobiographies, and narratives in Victorian America with particular reference to the Civil War, see Anne Rose, *Victorian America and the Civil War* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 245-255.

Virginia; or, Campaigning with the 149th Ohio Volunteer Infantry, a Sketch of Events Connected with the Service of the Regiment in Maryland and the Shenandoah Valley, Virginia counted as a regimental history because the work dealt with the experiences and services of the regiment as a corporate body. On the other hand, a work such as David Day's *My Diary of Rambles with the 25th Mass. Volunteer Infantry, with Burnside's Coast Division, 18th Army Corps, and Army of the James* could not be included on the chart even though the author made reference to a particular regiment. Day's title implies that he describes his personal experiences rather than the service of the regiment or the campaigns of the regiment.¹⁹ In cases of doubt as to whether the work counted as regimental history or a personal reminiscence, factors such as the presence or absence of a roster determined its inclusion or exclusion.

Fourth, all regimental histories that appeared during this time frame were included, regardless of whether or not the author served with the particular regiment. In several instances, friends or associates of the regiment penned the regimental history, often in close contact with actual members of the regiment. Though these sorts of works are few and far between, they fall in the genre of regimental history.²⁰

¹⁹ George Perkins, *A Summer in Maryland and Virginia; or, Campaigning with the 149th Ohio Volunteer Infantry, A Sketch of Events Connected with the Service of the Regiment in Maryland and the Shenandoah Valley* (Chillicothe: [School Print Co.], 1911); David Day, *My Diary of Rambles with the 25th Mass. Volunteer Infantry, with Burnside's Coast Division, 18th Army Corps, and Army of the James* ([Milford: King & Billings, printers] 1884).

²⁰ Two instances of this demonstrate why their inclusion is appropriate. Alfred S. Roe, a regimental historian whose work on his own regiment's history was esteemed, was contacted by several other regimental associations to pen their histories. See Alfred S. Roe and Charles Nutt, *History of the First*

Finally, it should be noted that the chart illustrates only regimental histories and not the total literary output regarding the Civil War. Memoirs, personal narratives, and articles experienced a renaissance in the 1880s.²¹ For this reason, the chart cannot be read as indicative as the interest of the public in the Civil War, but only as a measure of when regimental histories were published.

The chart displays 521 regimental histories published from 1863 until 1921. The average year saw publication of 9 regimental histories. Of these 521 regimental histories, William F. Fox listed 155 as members of his Fighting Three Hundred.²² This means that of the regimental histories, nearly 30% were written by regiments that had suffered severe combat losses. The distribution of publication relates closely to the economic cycle of America at the time. As noncommercial endeavors, regimental histories relied upon the contribution of large sums of money by regimental associations to underwrite

Regiment of Heavy Artillery Massachusetts Volunteers, Formerly the Fourteenth Regiment of Infantry, 1861-1865 ([Worcester: Commonwealth Press] 1917). Another example of this type of regimental is Mary G. G. Brainard, compiler, *Campaign of the One Hundred and Forty-Sixth Regiment New York State Volunteers, also Known as Halleck's Infantry, the Fifth Oneida, and Garrard's Tigers* (New York: G.P. Putnam's Sons, 1915).

²¹ The proliferation of literature in the 1880s is described in some detail by Linderman, *Embattled Courage*, 275-279 and David Blight, *Race and Reunion: The Civil War in American Memory* (Cambridge: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2001), 211-299.

²² William F. Fox, *Regimental Losses in the American Civil War 1861-1865: A Treatise on the Extent and Nature of the Mortuary Losses in the Union Regiments, With Full and Exhaustive Statistics Compiled from the Official Records on File in the State Military Bureaus and at Washington* (Albany: Brandow Printing Company, 1898).

publication. For this reason, economic recessions and cycles greatly influenced production. While Gerald Linderman and David Blight predicted the large numbers of Civil War publications in the 1880s, they did not forecast the large number of histories that appeared in 1865 and 1866.

In 1865 and 1866, 51 regimental histories appeared. Of these 51, 27 arrived in 1865 and 24 in 1866. This scale is nearly three times the yearly average for the entire time span. Of this cohort, Fox's Fighting Three Hundred named 17, or 33%.

II. The Authors of Regimental Histories, 1865-1866

Authors of the regimental histories published in 1865 and 1866 presented a broad cross-section of the regiment, but were weighted towards officers. In particular, chaplains wrote a large portion of the regimental histories.²³

Author's Rank	# of Histories	Percentage of Total
Private	10	20%
Corporal	2	4%
Sergeant	4	8%
Lieutenant	4	8%
Captain	2	5%
Regimental Staff	6	12%
Surgeon	2	4%
Chaplain	12	24%
Major	4	8%
Colonel	2	4%
Other/Unknown	3	6%
Total	51	100% ²⁴

The most striking observation that emerges, besides the preponderance of chaplains as authors, is the high number of privates. Overall, nearly a third of all regimental histories were authored by men in the ranks (privates, corporals, and sergeants). Middle-class officers and other elites, while active in producing regimental histories, did not dominate;

²³ Starr, "The Grand Old Regiment," 23.

²⁴ Percentages rounded.

men in the ranks wrote histories, too. The most conspicuous absence from this list is a truly corporate author; a committee did not oversee or author any of these regimental histories written in 1865 and 1866.

Although committees did not author these histories, writers made use of materials from other members of the regiment and took great pains to be historically accurate. Harris Beecher used “extensive journals and memoranda kept by the author throughout his service” and “the journals and memoranda of others, which in the main have been corroborative of each other, or at least have enabled him to arrive at more correct results.” Beyond this, Beecher consulted the files of local newspapers. Henry Davidson utilized company records and personal records. In other instances, other members of the regiment or other officers vetted the manuscript. John Kinnear met with “Colonel Fahnestock” as well as “General Magee, Major Thomas, Dr. Guth, Captain Zinser, and others at Peoria, to have the manuscript examined before publication.” Lyman Pierce explained that his regimental history came from notes “taken upon the march, at the time the incidents recorded transpired” and he compared these notes “with those taken by others, and the *official* reports [emphasis in original].” After its completion, the manuscript was inspected “by Gen. Hatch, Gen. Coon and the field officers of the Second Iowa cavalry, all of whom have attested to its correctness; hence we claim for our book a degree of authenticity [sic] which no historian, not a participant in the events he records, can attain.”²⁵ An informal committee approach typified regimental histories composed in 1865 and 1866.

²⁵ Harris Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V. Where it Went, What it Saw, and What it Did* (Norwich: J.F. Hubbard, Jr., 1866), i-ii. Other regimental historians made extensive use of newspaper

It might be expected that regimental histories would be divided into those written by Republicans and those written by Democrats. Yet there was no obvious difference or distinction; indeed, the only clear authorial bias appears between regimental histories written by chaplains and histories written by other ranks.²⁶ Unsurprisingly, chaplains often treated the regimental history as a pulpit. Their sermonizing often took advantage of the war to comment upon the sins of alcohol and profanity. John Hanson, of the 6th Massachusetts Infantry, explained that “the worst enemy of the country” was “whiskey.” Its influence was so baleful that Hanson declared “no one cause has done so much damage, and so retarded our progress, as the use of whiskey. If it could be entirely discontinued, it would at any time have given our army a reinforcement of more than 100,000 men.” Such moralizing was not limited to New England units where one would

correspondence that they had written during the war. See: Stephen Fleharty, *Our Regiment, a History of the 102d Illinois Infantry Volunteers, With Sketches of the Atlanta Campaign, the Georgia Raid, and the Campaign of the Carolinas* (Chicago: Brewster & Hanscom, 1865), 5; William L. Hyde, *History of the One Hundred and Twelfth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers* (Fredonia: W. McKinstry & co., 1866), vi; and Amos Judson, *History of the Eighty-Third Regiment Pennsylvania Volunteers*, ed., James A. Trulock and Alice Rains Trulock ([1865]; Arlington: Stonewall House, 1985), unpaginated introduction; Henry M. Davidson, *History of Battery A, First Regiment Ohio Vol. Light Artillery* (Milwaukee: Daily Wisconsin Print. House, 1865), iii.; John R. Kinnear, *History of the Eighty-Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry, During its Term of Service* (Chicago: Tribune Company’s Book and Job Printing Office, 1866), v; Lyman B. Pierce, *History of the Second Iowa Cavalry, Containing a Detailed Account of Its Organization, Marches, and Battles in Which it has Participated; also, a Complete Roster of Each Company* (Burlington: Hawk-Eye Printing Establishment, 1865), iii.

²⁶ It may be argued that Chaplains as a whole would tend to be Republicans. However, many chaplains did not express either Democratic or Republican views.

expect temperance and Protestant uplift sentiment to be strongest. Chaplain Thomas Murphey, of the 1st Delaware Infantry, explained that “we have lost more than one victory, suffered more than one defeat, and buried many a brave man in consequence of the excessive use of rum.” While Murphey condemned liquor, he reserved his greatest antipathy for “profane swearing...probably the most common and flagrant sin of the army.” To illustrate its dangers, Murphey included an anecdotal story of a nameless New York soldier, from a likewise anonymous regiment, who “being behind the trenches in front of Petersburg one day, impiously remarked to his comrades, as a bullet whizzed past his head, ‘I out-flanked Christ that time.’” Later that day “and near the same spot, another bullet from a sharp-shooter’s musket struck him in the head.”²⁷

Typically, after detailing the numerous sins and moral dangers of camp life, chaplains made sure to note that the members of their regiment were saintly. Samuel Merrill, chaplain of the First Maine Cavalry, explained that “A British general in India, speaking of the regiment commanded by that noble Christian soldier, Colonel Havelock, paid them this compliment: ‘They are never drunk and they are never afraid.’ The same

²⁷ John W. Hanson, *Historical Sketch of the Old Sixth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteers During its Three Campaigns, in 1861, 1862, 1863, and 1864: Containing the History of the Several Companies Previous to 1861, and the Names and Military Record of Each Man Connected with the Regiment During the War* (Boston: Lee and Shepard, 1866), 218.; Thomas G. Murphey, *Four Years in the War: The History of the First Regiment of Delaware Veteran Volunteers (Infantry), Containing an Account of Marches, Battles, Incidents, Promotions, and the Names of All the Officers and Men who have been Connected with the Regiment from its Organization in 1861, to the Close of the War* (Philadelphia: James S. Claxton, 1866), 34, 147.

is true of the First Maine Cavalry.”²⁸ Chaplains, concerned with the moral status of their regiments, used the opportunity of the regimental history to explain the deadly, and in their eyes, immediate effects of sin.

Regimental histories written by men other than the chaplains, however, revealed a different side of things. Harris Beecher, of the 114th New York Infantry, remarked that “Chaplain Callahan preached a short sermon in the morning, to a small audience...Church service served to remind them of their former home habits.” Unlike the chaplains, Beecher saw that church service was sparsely attended, and by implication, most of the men in the regiment did not follow their home habits of temperance. According to Joshua Horton and Solomon Teverbaugh, of the 11th Ohio Infantry, “plans adopted to prevent drinking among the enlisted men” were “very foolish, as they certainly were inefficient, generally having the opposite effect from what was intended.” David Lathrop, of the 59th Illinois Infantry, acknowledged that whisky had a salutary effect in camp, because it broke the monotony by spurring men to pull pranks.²⁹ For

²⁸ Samuel H. Merrill, *The Campaigns of the First Maine and First District of Columbia Cavalry* (Portland: Bailey & Noyes, 1866), 22.

²⁹ Harris Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 64; Joshua H. Horton and Solomon Teverbaugh, *History of the Eleventh Regiment (Ohio Volunteer Infantry), Containing the Military Record, So far as it is Possible to Obtain it, of each Officer and Enlisted Man in the Command, a List of Deaths, an Account of the Veterans, Incidents of the Field and Camp, Names of the Three Months' Volunteers, Compiled from the Official Records* (Dayton: W.J. Shuey, 1866), 234; David Lathrop, *History of the Fifty-Ninth Regiment Illinois Volunteers; Or, a Three Years' Campaign through Missouri, Arkansas, Mississippi, Tennessee and Kentucky, with a Description of the Country, Towns, Skirmishes and Battles, Incidents, Casualties, and Anecdotes Met with on the Way* (Indianapolis: Hall & Hutchinson, 1865), 210.

most soldiers, alcohol represented not a danger but an amusement that helped break up the boredom of life in camp.

The cohort of 1865-1866 intended their histories to commemorate their service, rather than to secure any pecuniary advantage. Colonel W.W.H. Davis, in the preface to his history of the 104th Pennsylvania, described how “when I re-entered the military service, in the fall of 1861, I became possessed of two hobbies; one, that of writing the history of my regiment, and the other, to have a monument erected to the memory of those whose might fall in action, or die of wounds or disease.” Moses Gage wrote a regimental history “at the urgent solicitation of the officers and men of the Regiment, whose service it records.” Moses Gage thought that “if the numerous friends of the Indiana soldiers are led to appreciate their services more fully by reading this volume, the aim of the author will be secured.”³⁰

Other authors expressed similar sentiments. W.H. Chamberlin explained that “the design of producing this little work originated in the belief that such a record, in a permanent form, would be acceptable to the living as a memento of their suffering and services in the War of the Rebellion, and that it might also serve as a slight tribute to the memory of those gallant and heroic members of our Regiment who have laid their lives upon their Country’s altar.” Henry Davidson had “no desire to gather laurels as an author. If the narrative is sufficiently readable to preserve fresh memories of each other

³⁰ William W. H. Davis, *History of the 104th Pennsylvania Regiment, from August 22nd, 1861, to September 30th, 1864* (Philadelphia: Jas. B. Rodgers, 1866), viii; Moses D. Gage, *From Vicksburg to Raleigh; or, a Complete History of the Twelfth Regiment Indiana Volunteer Infantry, and the Campaigns of Grant and Sherman, with an Outline of the Great Rebellion* (Chicago: Clarke & Co., 1865), v.

in the bosoms of my comrades in arms, – memories of the struggles, hardships, and dangers to which they were exposed in defence of the glorious flag of our united country, – my feeble efforts will have been amply rewarded.” The historian of the 189th New York Infantry “hoped any member of the command will find each historical sentence a text from which he may entertain his children and grand-children with stories of his soldier-deeds and sufferings which may otherwise have fallen into oblivion.” The authors of the history of the 11th Ohio Infantry included “several pages of good paper, neatly ruled” at the back of their book. Since the “book [was] intended as a ‘keepsake’ in the families of the members of the Regiment” the authors bound in the extra “paper in order that a fuller record of” each member’s service might be ensured. They directed that “wherever possible, this should be done by the hand of him who was a soldier, thus preserving the record in the handwriting of the soldier himself. It will be but a few years at best until all who took part in putting down the late gigantic rebellion will have passed away.”³¹ The primary focus of these historians was to commemorate service for the members of the regiment and their families.

Despite these professions, some regimental historians wrote with a larger audience in mind. Yet they still believed that this audience was composed of future historians, and that the primary purpose of the regimental history was commemoration.

³¹ William H. Chamberlin, *History of the Eighty-First Regiment Ohio Infantry Volunteers, During the War of the Rebellion* (Cincinnati: Gazette Steam-Printing House, 1865), 3; Davidson, *History of Battery A, First Regiment Ohio Vol. Light Artillery*, iii; William H. Rogers, *History of the One Hundred and Eighty-Ninth Regiment of New-York Volunteers* (New York: John A. Gray & Green, 1865), 5; Horton and Teverbaugh, *A History of the Eleventh Regiment (Ohio Volunteer Infantry)*, 121.

In the Preface to *The Seventh Regiment*, Chaplain F.T. Brown embarked on a lengthy justification for the history. He asked: “Were the doings of one regiment, among the thousands engaged in the war, of such interest as to demand a separate history?” The answer, of course, was affirmative: “but to perpetuate the fruits of this victory we must have records to the war – many records, made from many different points of view, and of many kinds, great and small.” Brown thought that “the history of this war is not yet written, perhaps cannot be successfully written for many years yet.” Especially important were regimental histories, because they did not attempt to relate the entire story of the war. Yet they would “be invaluable to the Bancroft, who fifty years hence, shall write the history of this war.” These considerations did not outweigh the regiment’s history, which was “of peculiar interest to its own especial friends.” General William T. Sherman, commenting on a regimental history, proclaimed that the work “must certainly be welcome to all members of the 102nd Ills. as well as friends of it. But the outside world cannot afford to read Regimental Histories because we had so many of them, that in detail they are too voluminous and can be condensed into histories of great Armies or Campaigns.”³² The history focused on the particular experiences of the regiment, and providing details for a future Bancroft served as a tertiary function.

Evidence suggests that authors and units published these histories in extremely limited numbers for distribution primarily to veterans and their families. Henry

³² George L. Wood, *The Seventh Regiment* [Ohio Infantry], *a Record* (New York: James Miller, 1865), 5-8; William T. Sherman to Stephen Fleharty, May 21, 1866, in possession of Sarah E. Glass, quoted in Philip J. Reyburn and Terry L. Wilson, eds., “Jottings from Dixie:” *The Civil War Dispatches of Sergeant Major Stephen F. Fleharty, U.S.A.* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1999), 30.

Davidson's *History of Battery A*, for example, enjoyed a small edition of only 250 copies. The regiment provided W.H. Chamberlin's *History of the Eighty-First Regiment Ohio Infantry Volunteers* free of charge to members of the regiment instead of selling copies. Joshua Horton and Samuel Teverbaugh recorded that they had "printed but a limited number" of their history. They added that the small edition size of the book drove the cost of the volume up. That the history sparked "little interest to any but members of and immediate friends of the regiment" precluded them from a larger print run. In his diary, Chaplain Louis N. Beaudry recorded progress on the history of the 5th New York Cavalry. He also took care to note that he "got subscriptions for 388 books, at a total price of \$1135."³³

III. Regimental Histories Interpret the War, 1865-1866

The majority of the content in regimental histories deals with such prosaic aspects of soldier life as marches, fatigue duty, picket, bivouac, and travel. Battles, skirmishes, and combat also compose a large segment of the regimental history. Yet prominent in nearly every regimental history is an explanation of what caused the Civil War. Their introductory generalizations were not superficial boilerplate pinned to the front of the regimental history; rather, the explanations given for the causes of the war resolve some seeming contradictions within the body of the regimentals. Union soldiers

³³ Davidson, *History of Battery A, First Regiment Ohio Vol. Light Artillery*, iii; Chamberlin, *History of the Eighty-First Regiment Ohio Infantry Volunteers*, 3; Horton and Teverbaugh, *A History of the Eleventh Regiment (Ohio Volunteer Infantry)*, xv; Louis N. Beaudry, *War Journal of Louis N. Beaudry, Fifth New York Cavalry: The Diary of a Union Chaplain, Commencing February 16, 1863* ed., Richard E. Beaudry (Jefferson, NC: McFarland, 1996), 232.

conceived of the Civil War as a battle of democracy against a slaveholding plutocracy in the South. In the South, slavery facilitated the creation of an aristocratic master class which subverted democracy. This aristocracy degraded the landscape and economy of the South and more importantly, degraded the common folk of the South. Slavery was thus “the cause of the rebellion.”³⁴ The goal of the Civil War was to restore the Union, but restoration necessitated the removal of slavery. While this interpretation of the Civil War may seem to be a simple recitation of beliefs held before the war, authors consistently sustained it within regimental histories.

The most significant aspects of this cosmology generally agree with the arguments made by Eric Foner in *Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party Before the Civil War*. Foner argued that “at the center of Republican ideology was the notion of ‘free labor,’” around which the Republican Party developed. Though Republicans manifested an antipathy toward slavery, their real preoccupation lay with “a justification of ante-bellum northern society.” They also believed in “a conspiratorial ‘Slave Power’ which had seized control of the federal government and was attempting to pervert the Constitution for its own purposes.” In sum, Foner argued that “Republicans’ enmity toward the South was intimately bound up with their loyalty to the society of small-scale capitalism which they perceived in the North. It was its identification with the aspirations of the farmers, small entrepreneurs, and craftsmen of northern society which gave the Republican ideology much of its dynamic, progressive,

³⁴ W[illia]m Sumner Dodge, *A Waif of the War; Or, a History of the Seventy-fifth Illinois Infantry, Embracing the Entire Campaigns of the Army of the Cumberland* (Chicago: Church and Goodman, 1866), 19.

and optimistic quality.”³⁵ When it came time for soldiers to reflect on the Civil War, they returned to prewar modes and methods of description rather than articulating any strikingly new conception of the North or the American nation.

Regimental historians thought that an aristocracy made possible by slavery was responsible for the Civil War. This aristocracy threatened the experiment of American democracy. A clue to this is found in the terminology used by regimental historians to describe the conflict that had just ended. The Civil War had not yet become the “Civil War.” Harris Beecher of the 114th New York Infantry alternately called the war “the great American Rebellion,” “the war of the Rebellion,” or “the monster Rebellion.” Most writers favored the term “rebellion,” though upon occasion they did use the term “Civil War.” Moses Gage of the 12th Indiana Infantry, wrote “of the Civil War in America,” but after this initial mention used the term “Great Rebellion.” Other authors were even more specific. Lyman Pierce of the 2nd Iowa Cavalry wrote of the “slave-drivers’ rebellion,” while Thomas Stevenson of the 78th Ohio Infantry used the term “slaveholders’ war.”³⁶ Avoidance of “Civil War” indicates that in 1865 and 1866, these men did not see the war as a conflict between two parties with equal standing. The war was a rebellion, an

³⁵ Eric Foner, *Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party Before the Civil War* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1970), 9, 316. For a more recent discussion of the historiography of the notion of the “Slave Power,” see Leonard L. Richards, *The Slave Power: The Free North and Southern Domination 1780-1860* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 2000), 1-27.

³⁶ Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 11, 12, 291; Moses Gage, *From Vicksburg to Raleigh*, ix; Pierce, *History of the Second Iowa Cavalry*, 9; Thomas M. Stevenson, *History of the 78th Regiment O[hio]. V[eteran]. V[olunteer]. I[nfantry]., from its “Muster-In” to its “Muster-Out,” Comprising its Organization, Marches, Campaigns, Battles and Skirmishes* (Zanesville: Hugh Dunne, 1865), v.

uprising – a deviation from the ordained and correct path. The purpose of fighting to preserve the Union was to preserve the trajectory and promise of the United States. Because the Union clearly had the moral high ground, regimental historians avoided terminology that would equate their cause with the Confederate cause.

Regimental historians explicitly defined the Great Rebellion as a clash between democratic free labor and a slave-based aristocracy. Harris Beecher noted that the “soldiers of the Southern States, sharing the former pride and haughtiness of our nationality” should have succeeded in their rebellion. They failed because “history nowhere tells us that aristocracy is the parent of successful revolution.” Rather, “it is only when the heart of labor has begun to throb under unendurable oppression that thrones are overturned and ministers beheaded.” After giving the English Revolution, the French Revolution, and the Reformation as examples of successful democratic revolt, he baldly stated that “the American rebellion was a revolt of the aristocracy” with “no nobler purpose than the enrichment of the privileged classes, and the still further degradation of the poor.” James Mowris assessed secession “as the handmaid and champion of a galling social despotism.” For Mowris, the source of this despotism was “slavery, like a deadly Upas planted beside the tree of Liberty.” Significantly, in artwork the Upas was a plant that symbolized original sin; slavery corrupted the United States in the same way that original sin corrupted man. Later Mowris asserted “that the late war...was nothing more nor less than a conflict between Aristocracy and Republicanism.” Like Mowris, William E. Jones of the 161st New York Infantry could not resist the Biblical allusion. He compared how “the Jews crucified our Savior to falsify His claims to kingship – but in so doing actually brought about the fulfillment of His mission” with how “the South has

overreached herself, and, in attempting to break asunder the golden chain of our Union, she unwittingly *struck off the chains of the slave!*”³⁷

Other authors voiced similar opinions. Moses Gage wrote that the secessionists were “engage[d] in the Utopian scheme of founding a Southern Confederacy, based upon the declared right of capital to own the labor of a subject African race.” A.W.M. Petty of the 3rd Missouri Cavalry, who wrote his regimental history in the style of a diary, entered on the date of September 30, 1863: “In the absence of anything else to say at this point, we will remark that the institution of slavery, as it formerly existed in the United States was an injury to the nation and society.” Slavery created “that insatiable and ungovernable spirit of aristocracy which has for so many years been so prominently manifested by the lords of southern soil.” William Dodge stated that “our army fought for the maintenance of the Union: the rebel army for its disintegration, and the perpetuity of Slavery.” Dodge then forcefully added “*that emancipation of the negro and the fulfillment of the promises of the Declaration of Independence were the conditions of our national safety* [emphasis in original].” Thomas Murphey agreed, writing that “the [Emancipation] proclamation was not directed against slavery but the rebellion, except so far as the former is sustained by the latter.” Thomas Stevenson of the 78th Ohio Infantry remarked that “to suppress the rebellion without interfering with slavery, is an

³⁷ Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 12-15; James A. Mowris, *History of the One Hundred and Seventeenth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers (Fourth Oneida), from its Date of its Organization, August, 1862, till that of its Muster Out, June, 1865* (Hartford: Case, Lockwood, and co., 1866), 39-40, 191-192; William E. Jones, *The Military History of the One Hundred & Sixty-First New-York Volunteers, Infantry, from August 15th, 1862, to October 17th, 1865* (Bath: Hull & Barnes, 1865), 62.

absurdity... You cannot render nugatory [slavery's] effects by any teachings, compromises, or by principles of mental science. As well make a mocking-bird out of a moccasin snake."³⁸ These regimental historians identified slavery as the root cause of the Civil War. Slavery precipitated the war because it tainted the otherwise perfect conception of democratic government and liberty created by the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution. Slavery allowed the formation of an aristocracy that seized control and perverted the masses. The goal of the war, to reunite the Union, required that the aristocracy of the South be dethroned, which in turn required the end of slavery.

Thomas Murphey of the 1st Delaware Infantry explained why secession required a militant response from the North. He asked, "Remove one block from the arch of liberty, and is it not insecure? Will it not yield to the rude storm, and be thrown to the ground?... Take from the monument to Washington, on the bank of the Potomac, one of those granite blocks which the States have furnished, of which it is constructed, and how long will it be before the whole superstructure will tottle and fall?" Secession affected not only the South but also the entire democratic experiment of the United States. It would "bury beneath it for ever the hopes of the world for a free republican form of government." Henry Davidson noted "that the citizen soldiers of the army of the Republic" affirmed "the great experiment of self government." Beyond that, "Our

³⁸ Gage, *From Vicksburg to Raleigh*, 15; A.W. M. Petty, *History of the Third Missouri Cavalry from its Organization at Palmyra, Missouri, 1861, up to November Sixth, 1864, with an Appendix and Recapitulation* (Little Rock: J. Wm. Demby, 1865), 40; Dodge, *A Waif of the War*, 19-22; Murphey, *Four Years in the War*, 127; Stevenson, *History of the 78th Regiment O.V.V.I.*, 182-183.

manhood has been elevated and strengthened, and liberty and popular institutions every where recognized as a permanent outgrowth of American destiny.” Wood Wales of the 95th Illinois Infantry remarked that “the results of the war had now taught these people a different doctrine” than States’ Rights. The Civil War would “long remain fresh in their memories, and will descend to their posterity as a fearful warning against future attempts to dissolve and destroy the perpetual Union of the States established by the fathers.”³⁹ Here was a denial of the compact theory of the Constitution; republican liberty was made possible by the collective unity of the United States. Any attempt to destroy that unity would destroy liberty.

It followed that, because an aristocracy led the South to war, those under their domination were not entirely responsible for their actions. Soldiers demonized Confederate leaders, while voicing some degree of sympathy for the misled masses. Harris Beecher remarked that the soldiers of the South were “led by brave and experienced, though misguided military captains.” General Nathan Bedford Forrest was “a devil incarnate” who drove his men, described as “wretched victims of the slave aristocracy,” to the slaughter. James Clark recalled how Union soldiers, “as soon as they saw the [captured] rebel general began to sing out...‘They’re the chaps who keep up the war; if he was a private we’d have sympathy for him, but he is a leader.’” Edwin Houghton of the 17th Maine agreed with this sentiment. Describing how the regiment

³⁹ Murphey, *Four Years in the War*, 20; Davidson, *History of Battery A, First Regiment of Ohio Vol. Light Artillery*, 141; Wales W. Wood, *History of the Ninety-Fifth Regiment Illinois Infantry Volunteers from its Organization in the Fall of 1862, Until its Final Discharge from the United States Service, in 1865* (Chicago: Tribune’s co.’s Book and Job Printing Office, 1865), 200-201.

marched past Confederate General William Barksdale's grave, Houghton gleefully remarked, "Such is the reward of lawless ambition! A United States representative turned traitor to the country, whose laws he had sworn to uphold, and, paying the penalty of treason by death at the hands of the United States soldiers, buried in a blanket, with a pasteboard monument erected to his memory!" Samuel Hurst of the 73rd Ohio Infantry expressed the converse of this, writing "It was sad to look on the windrows of dead, even though they were enemies; for we knew that many had persuaded themselves that they were dying in a noble cause...driven on by reckless and conscienceless leaders...even in ignoble cause, went to their death unswervingly." Wales Wood took great delight in reporting that "Beauregard, Bragg, Pillow, Admiral Semmes, and others" were "returning disappointed and unattended to their homes, where, during the remainder of their lives, they are to experience that ignominy and shame which will ever attach to them as original and persistent traitors." Wood further commented, upon the occasion of marching past fire-eater William Lowndes Yancey's tomb, "the doctrine of secession, at the outset, would have been condemned by an overwhelming majority, had Yancey and his fanatical clique submitted the question to a fair vote of the people."⁴⁰

⁴⁰ Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 12; Pierce, *History of the Second Iowa Cavalry*, 104; James H. Clark, *The Iron Hearted Regiment: Being an Account of the Battles, Marches and Gallant Deeds Performed by the 115th Regiment N.Y. Vols., Also a List of the Dead and Wounded, an Account of Hundred of Brave Men Shot on a Score of Hard Fought Fields of Strife, a Complete Statement of Harper's Ferry Surrender, Sketches of the Officers, a History of the Flags and those who Bore Them, Together with Touching Incidents, Thrilling Adventures, Amusing Scenes, Etc., Etc., Etc.* (Albany: J. Munsell, 1865), 123; Edwin B. Houghton, *The Campaigns of the Seventeenth Maine* (Portland: Short & Loring, 1866), 96.;

Even General Robert E. Lee came in for censure in these regimental histories.

Vitriol directed at the great rebel chieftain remained strong at this time. Lee was not yet the “marble man” or the “Great American.” Chaplain Cudworth of the 1st Massachusetts Infantry recalled that the people of Fredericksburg “were generally disloyal, having been infected with the sophistry of Gen. Lee – that they must go with their State, without regard to the nation; as though a man owed greater allegiance to one thirty-sixth of a great country, because he happened to be born on its soil, than to the remaining thirty-five thirty-sixths!” Osceola Lewis, writing of the surrender at Appomattox, refused to refer to Lee by name. Instead, in Lewis’s account, when the Army of Northern Virginia was brought to bay, “its military genius, the wicked idol of deluded people, sueing from our Lieutenant General, stipulations for a surrender of arms (the only support of falsely claimed rights) and mock principles of a confederacy of treason.”⁴¹

The Southern masses were susceptible to such leaders because there was no public education comparable to that in the North. James Mowris described how “the non-educating policy peculiar to the southern states, subjects the masses to the direction of a few politicians.” It was “convenient to the demagogue, but degrading to the people; unprofitable to the State, and signally disastrous to the nation.” Robert Eden of the 37th

Samuel H. Hurst, *Journal-History of the Seventy-Third Ohio Volunteer Infantry* (Chillicothe: n.p., 1866) 144-145; Wood, *History of the Ninety-Fifth Regiment Illinois Infantry Volunteers*, 186, 200.

⁴¹ Warren H. Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry), from the 25th of May, 1861, to the 25th of May, 1864, Including Brief References to the Operations of the Army of the Potomac*, 311; Osceola Lewis, *History of the One Hundred and Thirty- Eighth Regiment, Pennsylvania Volunteer Infantry* (Norristown: Wills, Iredell & Jenkins, 1866), 159-160.

Wisconsin Infantry pronounced Southern newspapers “tools of the rebel government” that were “well calculated to deceive the unlettered masses of the South.”⁴² Generally, it seemed that Northerners absolved the common folk of the South of responsibility, blaming machinations of the slave-holding elite for their ignorance.

Beyond lack of education, authors commented on the degraded and dirty nature of white Southerners, driving home the effects of slavery on the white inhabitants of the South. James Mowris unequivocally asserted that “a practical Democracy engenders no distinct class of ‘poor white trash’ groveling in hopeless ignorance over beyond the impassable gulf of social caste.” George Wood of the 7th Ohio Infantry wrote that the South’s “ambition was to have capital control labor, while the laboring classes were to be subservient to the capitalists, and a sort of serfdom forced upon them.” The slave aristocracy effectively negated democracy and called into being a poor underclass. Poor whites in the South seemed to prefigure the impending serfdom of which Wood wrote. Other soldiers commented on the poor underclass of whites in the South and their indolence. William Hurst thought that Alabama possessed “abundant ‘white trash,’ which, though not the whitest, was yet the trashiest we had ever seen. They were such wretched, sallow, squalid, ragged and unclean starvelings as only a land of ‘chivalry’ could produce.” John Kinnear, writing of “farming in the Southern states,” believed that Southerners “as a people...have no enterprise; they live only to eat, and even that is done

⁴² Mowris, *History of the One Hundred and Seventeenth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers*, 68; Robert C. Eden, *The Sword and the Gun: A History of the 37th Wis. Volunteer Infantry, from its First Organization to its Final Muster Out* (Madison: Atwood & Rublee, 1865), 40.

in a poor, unhandy style.”⁴³ Northern soldiers drew a direct link between the slaveocracy and poor white trash.

The degradation among the poor also extended to the battlefield, where Confederate soldiers were often described as barbarous. William Clark described that when the rebels charged “they came with their usual barbarous yell, and their dirty stars and bars led the advance.” Clark also recounted that “the beautiful and rich valley of the Shenandoah used to swarm with a class of men, who were good Union farmers in the day-time, and bloody guerillas at night...They were loyal when surrounded by northern bayonets, but would stab you to the heart at every opportunity. Some of their deeds would horrify the hardest heart, and chill the warmest blood. Yet they were done in the name of the Confederate States of America!” Other authors shared Clark’s opinion that the Confederates were barbarous and uncivilized. Osecola Lewis of the 138th Pennsylvania Infantry recalled how the Confederates at Mine Run “sallied forth...waving their red battle-flags in traitorous defiance, and screeching and yelling like demons.” Samuel Merrill of the 1st Maine Cavalry believed that history “will show that the treachery and savage barbarity of the red man of 1675, was more than equaled by those of the white man in interest of the great rebellion of 1861.” Warren Cudworth complained that Southern soldiers “remained obstinately under cover.” This was “a kind of warfare well calculated to test the valor of the bravest men; and neither few nor weak were the maledictions heaped upon these skulking exponents of Southern chivalry for

⁴³ Mowris, *History of the One Hundred and Seventeenth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers*, 170; Wood, *The Seventh Regiment*, 17; Hurst, *Journal-History of the Seventy-Third Ohio*, 84; Kinnear, *History of the Eighty-Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 135-137.

refusing fair fight in the open field.”⁴⁴ To Northern soldiers, at least, Southern professions of chivalry amounted to mere sophistry and concealed a true barbaric nature.

Authors also related examples of Confederate malfeasance in the aftermath of combat. Evan Woodward wrote with horror how “leg bones were also found with the marrow but partially dried up in them, from which finger rings have been sawed off.” Woodward took this as further evidence of the “singular and refined tastes [of] the chivalry of the South.” In a similar vein, authors whose regiments passed by Chickamauga battlefield commented with distress on how Confederates extended their barbarity even to the treatment of Union dead. John Kinnear wrote that “here and there could be seen the putrified form of some human creature in Union garb. Sometimes the skull and other members of the body were seen detached along the road-side or on a stump, having been taken from their peaceful repose by ruthless hands or hungry dogs.” Louis Simmons of the 84th Illinois noticed that “the dead of our army had received much less attention. It was evident that they had been dragged into heaps, and logs, brush and stones, or a small quantity of dirt thrown upon them.”⁴⁵

⁴⁴ Clark, *The Iron Hearted Regiment*, 106, 5-6; Lewis, *History of the One-Hundred and Thirty-Eighth Regiment, Pennsylvania Volunteer Infantry*, 52; Merrill, *Campaigns of the First Maine and District of Columbia Cavalry*, 25-26; Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry)*, 55.

⁴⁵ Evan Woodward, *Our Campaigns: Or, the Marches, Bivouacs, Battles, Incidents of Camp Life and History of our Regiment During its Three Year Term of Service, Together with a Sketch of the Army of the Potomac, Under Generals McClellan, Burnside, Hooker, Meade and Grant* [31st Pennsylvania Infantry] (Philadelphia: John E. Potter and co., 1865), 91; Kinnear, *History of the Eight-Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 38; Simmons, *History of the 84th Reg't Ill. Vols.* (Macomb: Hampton Brothers, 1866), 137.

Barbarity extended beyond Confederate soldiers to southern women, who appear in the regimental histories as vile harridans who shower imprecations and insults upon the infidel Yankee invaders. The historian of the 114th New York Infantry wrote of a widow who “unlike many of her neighbors, remained at home, and stormed and fretted over ‘the thieving propensities of the contemptible Yankees.’ Her daughter, in the meanwhile, persisted in thumping a discordant piano, and singing with ear-piercing shrillness the tune of the ‘Bonnie Blue Flag.’” Martin Haynes of the 2nd New Hampshire Infantry disgustedly wrote of how “the Williamsburg ladies – so they called themselves – visited these hospitals” that had been set up for the wounded during the Peninsula Campaign in 1862. While visiting wounded rebels, they would take “every occasion to insult and wound the feelings of the” Union injured “in the most outrageous manner...and utter some insulting remarks concerning ‘cowardly Yankees’ or ‘vile invaders.’” Stephen Fleharty, somewhat amusedly, recalled how “One elderly lady pointed her bony finger at the writer and said: ‘Mark my word, this war will never end until there is a Southern Confederacy.’ But the fine rhetoric of the ladies was not sufficient to save it.”⁴⁶

⁴⁶ Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 173-174. For a similar, though slightly different account of this episode, see Elias P. Pellett, *History of the 114th Regiment, New York State Volunteers, Containing a Perfect Record of Its Services, Embracing All Its Marches, Campaigns, Battles, Sieges, and Sea-Voyages, With a Biographical Sketch of Each Officer, and a Complete Register of the Regiment, Wherein Appears the Name of Every Officer and Enlisted Man who has Ever Belonged to the Same, with Full Remarks Relating Thereto* (Norwich: Telegraph & Chronicle Power Press Print co., 1866), 76-77; Martin A. Haynes, *History of the Second Regiment, New Hampshire Volunteers, Its Camps, Marches, and Battles* (Manchester: Charles F. Livingston, 1865), 60; Fleharty, *Our Regiment*, 40.

A tension thus existed in regimental histories, whereby at times Confederates could be vile and barbarous, but at others free of responsibility because they had been misled by the aristocracy. Regimental historians exhibited a sort of cognitive dissonance, by turns condemning and exculpating Southerners. Nothing was fundamentally wrong about the common folk of the South; their degraded condition was due to their corrupt leadership. Thus, it made sense to believe that “the rank and file of the Rebel army will return to a cordial submission to our laws.” Samuel Merrill explained that “the leading idea” among the defeated Confederates “seemed to be this: The matter of difference between the North and South had been submitted to the arbitration of arms. The battle has been a fair one, and we have lost it.” According to George Powers, “the paroled rebel soldiers, to their credit be it said, were unanimous in denouncing the assassination [of Lincoln]; and were determined to allow of no guerilla warfare in the State, now that the main armies had surrendered. Perfect good feeling existed between the late belligerents.” Wales Wood related that surrendered Confederates were “perfectly satisfied with the result of the war, and claimed that they had never been in favor of it from the beginning. Many of these soldiers were honest in such assertions, and had been forced into the ranks by that reign of terror which the leading traitors had instituted and carried out to advance their base schemes and sustain their rotten Confederacy.”⁴⁷

⁴⁷ Louis Naploeon Boudrye, *Historic Records of the Fifth New York Cavalry, First Ira Harris Guard, Its Organization, Marches, Raids, Scouts, Engagements, and General Services during the Rebellion of 1861-1865, with Observations of the Author by the Way, Giving Sketches of the Armies of the Potomac and of the Shenandoah. Also, Interesting Accounts of Prison Life and of the Secret Service. Complete Lists of its Officers and Men* (Albany: S.R. Gray, 1865), 196; Merrill, *Campaigns of the First Maine and District of*

Historians viewed the physical landscape of the South much as they did the population. The South was a great land of promise and fecundity. Yet once historians began to comment on the sections of the landscape that had been modified by Southerners, they became much more critical. Just as the slave power had corrupted the people of the South, so also had it corrupted the land. All was not lost, however, because the Civil War provided the opportunity to rehabilitate the land and allow the South to live up to its full potential.

Regimental historians often commented favorably on the Southern landscape. To them, the South appeared as an exotic and interesting locale, filled with fascinating sights and strange creatures. Histories of units that served in the more exotic and far-flung regions of the South commented favorably on the flora and fauna. John Kinnear, of the 86th Illinois Infantry, described with rapture the landscape in northern Georgia: “This vicinity of the South is noted for its grand natural scenery, nowhere to be surpassed. We read of the romantic scenery of the Oriental world – of the versatility of Italia’s summer winds – of the magic charms of her hills, her rills, and dales; but the realities here presented are more enchanting than the probabilities of a might be in other parts of the world.” Beyond the landscape, authors described “alligators of immense dimensions and familiar habits; moccasin snakes of domestic tendencies, crawling into the tents for shelter and frequently monopolizing the blankets of the men.” Another history of the same regiment went into further detail, discussing the swamps of Louisiana: “Alligators

Columbia Cavalry, 369; George W. Powers, *The Story of the Thirty-Eighth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteers* (Cambridge: Dakin and Metcalf, 1866), 206; Wood, *History of the Ninety-Fifth Regiment Illinois Infantry Volunteers*, 199.

splash and paddle lazily in the turbid pools; snakes also inhabit the waters, or hiss from the trees; owls, lizards, and tarantulas abound, and dense clouds of insects, poisonous and irritating, infest the air.”⁴⁸

While historians may have been inclined to view the landscape of the South with wonder, they took a more jaundiced view of Southern towns. James Clark of the 115th New York remarked that “Annapolis is not a pretty town. Although it is noted in history, there is nothing grand or imposing in her appearance in 1862. The streets are narrow and dirty. The buildings, even on the principal squares, are fast going to decay. The once sparkling halls of fashion cease to dazzle with jewels and shine with beauty.” Although Annapolis was not in the Confederacy, Clark saw it as tainted by Maryland’s Southern leanings. Similarly, Chaplain Warren Cudworth of the 1st Massachusetts Infantry decided that “Yorktown, at this time, like most Virginia settlements, was in a state of dilapidation and decay. Notwithstanding its historical importance, there did not seem to be enterprise enough among its inhabitants to keep it in a neat and respectable condition.”⁴⁹ The decay and decline of these towns so important during the Revolution provided a concrete example of the South’s decline from and rejection of the ideas of the American Revolution.

Just as authors were keen to point out the deficiencies of the South, they were quick to assess ways to make the South better. The chaplain of the 5th New York

⁴⁸ Kinnear, *History of the Eight- Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 37-38; Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 130; Pellet, *History of the 114th Regiment, New York State Volunteers*, 92.

⁴⁹ Clark, *The Iron Hearted Regiment*, 32; Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry)*, 141.

Cavalry, Louis Boudrye, was “peculiarly impressed with the vastness of the forests” of Virginia. He was surprised because this was “different...from the impressions we had formed of Virginia when reading of its early settlement, and its agricultural advantages.” To Boudrye, it was perplexing that so much productive land lay unused beneath the trees. It was clear that the “system of labor” was the cause “of this backwardness in agricultural pursuits.” If only the people could “realize the true dignity of labor,” then “the almost interminable forests disappear, and in their places the industrious yeoman will behold his rich fields of waving grain.” With the yeoman would come the “factory and the mill, whose fabrics bring wealth and prosperity to the nation.” Others shared Boudrye’s sentiments. George Kinnear “could not refrain from laughing at their oddity in agricultural pursuits.” Warren Cudworth thought that the area near Williamsburg, Virginia was “remarkable alike for its beauty and fertility, and in proper hands might be made a paradise,” but “a new race was evidently needed to save the land from sinking into a wilderness.” The historians of the 11th Ohio Infantry believed that the Kanawha Valley of West Virginia “for productiveness can not be excelled. Abounding in all the most useful minerals – salt, coal, and oil to be had almost for the asking, nothing but a moderate degree of ‘Yankee’ enterprise is needed to make this most remarkable valley more valuable than the mines of California or Australia.”⁵⁰ Now that the aristocracy and slavery had been overthrown, there was nothing left to prevent Yankee enterprise from improving the land.

⁵⁰ Boudrye, *Historic Records of the Fifth New York Cavalry*, 135; Kinnear, *History of the Eight- Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 135; Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry)*, 184; Horton and Teverbaugh, *History of the Eleventh Regiment (Ohio Volunteer Infantry)*, 27.

The institution of slavery posed a primary obstacle toward improving the land.

A wide variety of sentiment existed regarding slavery and those subjected to it. On one extreme, regimental historians advocated emancipation and equality with blacks; on the other extreme historians denigrated blacks and used their amusing behavior as a sort of comic relief. In between these two extremes lay the bulk of regimental histories, wherein the authors were sympathetic on the whole towards blacks but this sympathy was expressed and circumscribed by racism.

On one extreme lay Chaplain Warren Cudworth's *History of the First Regiment Massachusetts Infantry*. As might be expected from a chaplain from Boston, Cudworth took a remarkably tolerant and understanding view of African American culture.

Cudworth noted that slaves "greeted our coming among them with almost unconcealed delight, and were of the greatest possible service." Cudworth enthusiastically welcomed the "Proclamation of Emancipation...whose appearance he hailed with delight, and whose influence in deciding the doom of the Rebellion he felt to be potent and irresistible. It was better than many victories gained by gunpowder and battalions; being a declaration for justice and righteousness." Another chaplain, Moses Gage, admonished: "Let none say that the bondmen do not love their liberty, when such cheerfulness is manifested in the midst of trials attendant upon the pursuit of that object." John Hanson, chaplain of the 6th Massachusetts, wrote eloquently of "the long files of dusky pilgrims [that] came in...dragging the household penates." Though these escaped slaves presented a ragged appearance, Hanson "found them intelligent as, and every way the equals, and in

ability to take of themselves the superiors of, the white people left in our neighborhood.”⁵¹

In contrast to other authors who were amused by scenes of African-American religious services, Hanson of the 6th Massachusetts Infantry “was very much interested in the fact that worshippers would pray with great fervor for our soldiers. One eloquent petition referred to them as dashing through the ‘roar of cannon, the smoke of battle, and the flash of the rifle,’ and supplicated the Divine protection for them, in terms that would have done honor to any prayer.” In another incident, Hanson was invited to officiate alongside a black preacher. He gratefully attended the service, “and with an audience of white and black, of ministers and laity, and of many denominations, we, a Universalist and Methodist preacher, administered the communion. It seemed a foregleam of the millennium, as we all worshipped together; for, though speaking many sectarian dialects, we were united in one spirit.”⁵²

Though chaplains most often exhibited this tolerance, other regimental histories sometimes proved to be sympathetic to the plight of slaves. Lyman Pierce of the 2nd Iowa Cavalry exclaimed “What a comment upon the institution of slavery, that it crushes even *poor whites*, with whom it comes in contact, until every spark of manhood becomes extinct. Who, after such a sight, will brand the black race as unfit for freedom, and assign as a reason for the course the fact that they lack the snap usually seen in the free Anglo-Saxon of the North? Can we expect the negro to withstand the direct influence of

⁵¹ Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry)*, 90, 336; Gage, *From Vicksburg to Raleigh*, 293; Hanson, *Historical Sketch of the Old Sixth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteers*, 161.

⁵² Hanson, *Historical Sketch of the Old Sixth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteers*, 169-170.

an institution, the indirect contact of which has so degraded our race?” Major George Wood, of the 7th Ohio Infantry from the abolitionist hotbed of the Western Reserve, wrote the most understanding account of slavery. Wood was “confident that the slaves of the South, were just as well informed with regard to their relation to their masters, as we were.” Wood continued that “it is well enough to talk of the deep devotion of slaves to their masters; but the later have found ere this, I trust, that this devotion on which they have relied, has not prevented them from cutting their throats, when it was in the line of their duty, and by means of which they could gain their freedom.” Wood realized that slaves “obtain[ed] scraps of newspapers and parts of books, and thus gain a great deal of information entirely unobserved.” After discussing at some length how slaves worked for their own freedom when given the chance, he waxed elegiac: “What a glorious thought! thousands of the oppressed fighting for the redemption from slavery of a race which has ever worn the chain. When it is remembered that by this strife questions are to be settled which have ever disturbed the harmony of this country, and not only that, but questions which, when settled, will release millions of our fellow-men and women from the power of the oppressor, ought we not to be thankful that we are permitted to make great sacrifices in so good a cause?”⁵³

⁵³ Pierce, *History of the Second Iowa Cavalry*, 120; Wood, *The Seventh Regiment*, 77-78, 81-82.

Chamberlin’s *History of the Eighty-First Regiment Ohio Infantry Volunteers* contains a sympathetic account of contrabands coming in to Union lines, as well as an account of how freed slaves quickly sought to marry as soon as they realized they had that opportunity, 37, 42. Another regimental includes a scene of great disapproval of slavery, as well as an account from the postwar that comments favorably on blacks in Mobile being “orderly and well conducted,” as opposed to Southern whites, J. Irvine Dungan, *History of the Nineteenth Regiment Iowa Volunteer Infantry* (Davenport: Luse & Griggs, 1865), 109, 171.

On the other extreme were regimental histories like that of Robert Eden. Eden wrote disparagingly of the “crowd of darkies ‘Hurrahing and Hallelujahing’ around us, accompanying their expressions of delight with a grotesque exhibition of antics and grimaces, and ‘*Bressing* de Lord and the Yankees [emphasis in original].” Stephen Fleharty also asserted that “the only class of people that seemed contented amid so much misery was the colored community.” Perhaps betraying a somewhat lascivious fascination with blacks, Fleharty described how his “mind reverts to one or two sleek, sable lasses who were accustomed to dance on the pavement with every manifestation of ecstatic delight.” He also lamented: “Poor creatures, they scarcely realized their own wretchedness.” Chaplain Samuel Merrill, of the 1st Maine and District of Columbia Cavalry, argued that “freedom you can give at once” but “the right to make contracts, the obligations of which are equally binding on both parties...you cannot so readily confer.” If not handled correctly, the aftermath of abolition might lead to “the most dreadful of all wars, a war of races.”⁵⁴

Harris Beecher’s *Record of the 114th Regiment N.Y.S.V.* typified the bulk of regimental histories, in terms of sentiment toward slaves. Beecher remarked that “it will take many years of education, and the enlightening effects of freedom, to bring [blacks] up to the proper standard of intelligence.” For Beecher, slavery and the lack of education accounted for the degradation of blacks; race did not determine their inferiority, but rather environmental factors. While the regiment spent time in Louisiana, Beecher recalled that the men “had a fine opportunity to study the character of the negro” and

⁵⁴ Eden, *The Sword and the Gun*, 51; Fleharty, *Our Regiment*, 29, 125; Merrill, *Campaigns of the First Maine and District of Columbia Cavalry*, 373-374.

“some of the most revolting spectacles connected with the ‘divine institution.’”⁵⁵

Despite these realizations, Beecher included several passages in dialect with the intent of mimicking the tradition of the minstrel show.⁵⁶ He also could not overcome prejudice toward African-American religion. As Beecher remembered, “one of the chief sources of amusement, among the soldiers, was in visiting negro dances, and prayer meetings. These last are the most singular and impressive sights imaginable, consisting of weird songs, incoherent irreverent shouts, mingled with violent contortion, wails and moans, quaint prayers and responses.” Later, Beecher complained that “the night was made hideous by their dances and prayer meetings, disturbing the sleep of the men.”⁵⁷ Like many other regimental historians, Beecher blamed the institution of slavery for the apparent inferiority of blacks but could not escape the patronizing language and prejudice of the time.

Other historians concurred with Beecher’s views. W.W.H. Davis viewed African-American religious services unfavorably; “it was evidently a heathen ceremony handed down from their African ancestors, somewhat modified by their Christian training.” Samuel Hurst likewise equivocated; he “witnessed the workings of the *plantation system of negro* slavery without being charmed with either the humanity or chivalric element of Southern civilization [emphasis in original].” Yet this was not coupled with any sentiment other than the fact that “many [blacks] were ignorant and degraded as brutes

⁵⁵ Harris Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V. Where it Went, What it Saw, and What it Did* (Norwich: J.F. Hubbard, Jr., 1866), 80, 114

⁵⁶ For instances of dialect, see: Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 107, 149, 186.

⁵⁷ Beecher, *History of the 114th Regiment, N.Y.S.V.*, 114-115, 264.

almost; but some were intelligent.” John Kinnear also manifested an ambivalence concerning blacks. He maintained that “one thing is true, despite the unworthiness they bear on many minds, [blacks] were the only friends on whom we could rely for the sacred truth in the sunny land of Dixie.”⁵⁸ However, Kinnear thought that a stampede of black refugees following Sherman’s column that resulted in hundreds drowning in Ebenezer Creek was “at once a laughable and pitiful sight...Many of the women, with the darling calamity of their bosom in their arms, were washed under by the swift current to rise no more.”⁵⁹

Although attitudes of regimental historians toward blacks varied greatly, virtually all agreed that the Civil War required the end of slavery. They explained how the course of the war had brought them around to this opinion. This encapsulates the general trend within regimental histories; slavery precipitated the war, and as the war dragged on the men came to accept the necessity of ending slavery. Some men had supported this position before the war, but most had not. Finally, striking at slavery was a way at striking at the aristocracy of the South and did not necessarily entail equality, rights, or tolerance for blacks. Warren Cudworth noted that once the Emancipation Proclamation went in to effect, “the regiment took it much more kindly than they had taken

⁵⁸ Davis, *History of the 104th Pennsylvania Regiment*, 211; Samuel H. Hurst, *Journal-History of the Seventy-Third Ohio Volunteer Infantry* (Chillicothe: n.p., 1866), 155-156; Kinnear, *History of the Eight-Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 81.

⁵⁹ Kinnear, *History of the Eight-Sixth Regiment Illinois Volunteer Infantry*, 84-85. For an account of this incident, see Joseph Glatthaar, *The March to the Sea and Beyond: Sherman’s Troops in the Savannah and Carolinas Campaigns* (New York: New York University Press, 1985), 64.

considerable abolition preaching in former times, showing that the unanswerable logic of events had effected a change for the better.” James Mowris explained that when the “President issued the Emancipation Proclamation [t]here were few among us who regarded the act with positive disfavor. The measure elicited some warm discussion, but not enough feeling to effect the social unity of the organization.” Thomas Murphey likewise noticed that “the change of opinion among the soldiers in regard to slavery, negro enlistments, and emancipation was remarkable.”⁶⁰

Historians were less ambiguous regarding African-American troops. Regiments that had exposure to United States Colored Troops (USCT) were inclined to praise them and commented favorably on their appearance. Chaplain Louis Boudrye remarked that “a brigade of colored troops occupy Old Church. They have fortified themselves with strong and beautifully constructed earthworks. They are fine appearing soldiers.” Other soldiers took delight in the fact that former slaves were now in control of their masters. Elias Pellet crowed that “it was a source of infinite satisfaction to us, ‘Northern mud-sills,’ to see the ‘chivalry,’ the lords of broad acres, obliged to exhibit their ‘passes’ to the dark skinned sentinels – men, who in some cases, were formerly their ‘chattels.’” Edwin Houghton of the 17th Maine Infantry noted with glee that “official intelligence was also received during the day, that the negro soldiers had taken possession of the long coveted city of Richmond. The joy that gladdened the hearts of all, at the intelligence of the fall of the proud and arrogant head-quarters of treason, was not diminished by the fact, that

⁶⁰ Cudworth, *History of the First Regiment (Massachusetts Infantry)*, 336; Mowris, *A History of the One Hundred and Seventeenth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers*, 57; Murphey, *Four Years in the War*, 74.

the pride of the great southern metropolis had been humbled, and that it had been reserved for the colored soldiers to capture the rebel capital.”⁶¹

Soldiers who observed USCT units in combat were even more effulgent in their praise. James Clark of the 115th New York Infantry watched as the USCT of the Ninth Corps charged rebel positions at the Battle of the Crater in July 1864: “Noble fellows! Grandly they cross the field; they are under a withering fire, but still rush on regardless of fallen comrades, and the storm of pitiless lead and relentless grape that pours upon them from three sides, and gain the works with a ringing cheer. Now they sweep everything before them.” James Mowris, writing of the Battle of Deep Bottom, recalled “on that occasion, those who were politically the most conservative, suddenly experienced, an accession of respect for the chattel on this discovery of its ‘equal’ value in a possible emergency.” Thomas Murphey concurred that “the prejudices against negro soldiers began to give way before Petersburg. Once soldiers unwilling to have them associated with them in the same army, but after the experience in battles on the north of the James, in charging upon fortified positions, they were very willing...to have colored troops come up before the entrenchments around Petersburg.” The charge of General Steadman’s “Negro Brigade” at the Battle of Nashville elicited similar comments from Louis Simmons of the 84th Indiana Infantry; “But danger and death did not cause them to waver a moment, nor repress the terrible fury of their victorious charge. They stormed and took a line, that one of the best Brigades in our whole army had failed to carry. Yet these were the men who were recently chattels; whom we were so reluctant to see

⁶¹ Boudrye, *Historic Records of the Fifth New York Cavalry*, 139; Pellet, *History of the 114th Regiment, New York State Volunteers*, 46; Houghton, *The Campaigns of the Seventeenth Maine*, 266.

mustered as soldiers, and of whom it had been so often said ‘they won’t fight.’”⁶²

George Powers resented press coverage of black troops engaged at Port Hudson, but while grumbling about the “exaggerated accounts of their bravery” understood “it had been the fashion for so long to decry the courage of the colored man, and deny him the attributes of manhood, that, when he proved himself more than a beast of burden, public opinion went to the opposite extreme.”⁶³

IV. Conclusion

A consensus existed among Union soldiers at the end of the war. The war had been fought over slavery, because slavery had encouraged the development of a Southern aristocracy. Foolishly, the aristocracy attempted to destroy the Union through the act of secession. Now that this aristocracy had been defeated, and slavery removed, the United States could continue on its path toward liberty and democracy based on the supremacy of free labor. Resentment towards the South focused on the aristocracy, not the common man. The death of slavery ensured that this aristocracy could not ensconce itself again. Antipathy towards slavery centered on the corrupting influence of slavery on white society in the South more than on any desire to better the African-American. Perhaps portending the fate of Reconstruction, distaste for slavery did not extend toward a

⁶² Clark, *The Iron Hearted Regiment*, 148; Mowris, *A History of the One Hundred and Seventeenth Regiment N.Y. Volunteers*, 113; Murphey, *Four Years in the War*, 174; Simmons, *History of the 84th Reg’t Illinois Vols.*, 227.

⁶³ It appears that Powers’ resentment is a case of sour grapes; the 38th Massachusetts Infantry was still an unblooded regiment at the time of Port Hudson, and thus had incurred no glory or accolades. George W. Powers, *The Story of the Thirty-Eighth Regiment of Massachusetts Volunteers* (Cambridge: Dakin and Metcalf, 1866), 90-91.

commitment to equality for the freedmen. Union soldiers believed that because slavery had been eradicated, the cause of the Civil War had been ameliorated and the United States could resume its proper course. For the soldiers, preservation of the Union necessitated the war, and an end to slavery would ensure that the slave-holding plutocrats could not retrench.

The implications of these views extend far beyond the views of individual soldiers. As concrete evidence of a soldier's service, the regimental history provided a memento to his friends and family. The opinions articulated within a regimental history stood for the views of the soldier; the veteran spoke with authority to his home community about what they all had sacrificed for. The regimental history spoke with more authority than the newspaper or a massive, mass-produced commercial history of the war. It personally tied the home community to the war that had just ended, and suggested how that community should interpret and understand the conflict.

The findings presented here also point toward a broader reconceptualization of the causes and meaning of the Civil War. They exhibit continuity with prewar arguments of the slave power, and demonstrate that this interpretation of the war persisted even to the end. These findings also call into question some of the arguments of David Blight, who has written how a reconciliationist view of the Civil War squeezed out "emancipation from the national narrative of what the war had been about." For many veterans, the war had never been about emancipation. The war had been about preserving the Union, and the preservation of the Union required the elimination of aristocratic slaveholders. Even in 1865 and 1866 when wounds were fresh, these soldiers thought of the Southern masses as having been misled or perverted by the grandee slave owners. In short, an

emancipationist conception of the Civil War never held much prominence in their view. While many soldiers could empathize or feel sympathy for the African Americans they encountered, this did not mean that they saw emancipation as the primary goal of the war. Emancipation provided a stepping stone to the real goal of the war – preservation of democracy and republicanism through preservation of the Union.⁶⁴

⁶⁴ Historian Andre Fleche, in particular, has contextualized the American Civil War in terms of the 1848 revolutions and how the notion of the slave power meshed with the anti-aristocratic leaning of the turmoil in Europe. Andre Fleche, *The Revolution of 1861: The Legacy of the European Revolutions of 1848 and the American Civil War* (PhD Diss., University of Virginia, 2006); Blight, 5.

